



# China Trip Prep Checklist

Everything to sort out BEFORE you fly · from the China Survival Kit team

chinesewithjoy.net  
voiced by Joy, real Mandarin teacher

## 2-4 WEEKS BEFORE



### Check your visa / TWOV eligibility

Many nationalities transit visa-free — verify current rules on the official NIA site ([en.nia.gov.cn](http://en.nia.gov.cn)), not blogs.



### Book hotels that accept foreign guests

Filter for it on Trip.com / Booking. Many budget hotels legally can't check foreigners in.



### Book big attractions early

Forbidden City & top museums are passport-tied reservations, released ~7 days ahead. They sell out.



### Trains: book on Trip.com

12306 verification is painful with foreign numbers. Board with your passport — it IS the ticket.

## THE WEEK BEFORE



### Set up Alipay + WeChat Pay, add your card

Cash is nearly dead. Test one transaction at home if you can. Carry one backup card.



### Sort your internet: roaming eSIM or VPN

Install and TEST before flying — VPN sites are blocked inside China. Roaming eSIMs skip the firewall.



### Download offline maps + the offline phrasebook

Apple Maps works in China; Google Maps doesn't. Get China Survival Kit — it needs zero signal.



### Fill in your Emergency Card

Allergies, blood type, contact — in the app it auto-builds correct Chinese to show a doctor or waiter.

## KNOW BEFORE YOU LAND



### Emergency numbers: 120 · 110 · 119

Ambulance · police · fire. Not 911. Say "1" as **yāo**  
: 120 = yāo-èr-líng.



### Didi drivers ask your number's last 4 digits

手机尾号 — show the digits big instead of saying them. The app has a card for exactly this.



### No tipping

Taxis, restaurants, hotels — nobody expects it. Say 谢谢, 辛苦了 instead.



### Cash: carry a little anyway

¥200–500 for the rare cash-only stall. Most drivers can't break big notes.